

Payap University
The International College

IEC 342: Research Methods
Department of English Communication Arts

**Academic Challenges Faced by English Communication Arts Students at International
College, Payap University**

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Contents

(1) Introduction	3
(2) Literature Review	3
(3) Theoretical Framework	4
(4) Methodology	5
(5) Findings	5
(6) Discussion and Conclusion	8
6.1 Discussion	8
6.1.1 Limitations and Future Research	9
6.2 Conclusion	9
References	11

Abstract

This study investigates the main academic challenges faced by English Communication Arts (ECA) students at Payap University. Employing a mixed-methods approach, data were collected from fifteen survey participants and four interviewees. The results highlight three major academic stressors: heavy course workload and time pressure, difficulty in understanding lecturers' instructions, and problems related to group project coordination. Students reported using time-planning tools, peer support, and online resources as coping strategies, but they also emphasized the need for clearer feedback from lecturers. The findings suggest that while ECA students demonstrate resilience and responsibility, institutional and instructional adjustments are essential to foster a more supportive academic environment.

Keywords: academic stress, workload, time management, group project, coping strategies, feedback, English communication students, Payap University, Higher Education

(1) Introduction

University students frequently encounter numerous academic pressures, including heavy workloads, strict deadlines, and communication difficulties with lecturers. For international students, these challenges can be magnified by language barriers and cultural differences in learning styles. Within Payap University's English Communication Arts (ECA) program, students are required to complete multiple assignments, projects, and oral presentations in a single semester. These tasks not only demand strong academic performance but also time management, cooperation, and adaptability.

The purpose of this study is to identify the specific academic challenges ECA students face and to explore how they manage these pressures. Understanding their experiences will contribute to better teaching strategies, improved academic support systems, and a more effective learning atmosphere for international students.

(2) Literature Review

Several studies have examined the relationship between workload and academic stress. Misra and McKean (2000) found that students who fail to manage their time effectively often experience higher levels of anxiety and lower academic satisfaction. Similarly, Ahmady et al. (2021) reported that excessive academic workload can harm students' performance and overall well-being. Wong and Lai (2025) highlighted that developing structured time management habits significantly reduces stress and improves learning outcomes.

Emotional and social factors also play an important role. Au, Caltabiano, and Vaksman (2023) demonstrated that students with a strong sense of belonging and resilience are better equipped to cope with academic challenges. Bond and Bedenlier (2024) noted that engagement, both cognitive and emotional that is essential for managing workload and stress effectively. In addition, Liu, Shi, and Gao (2024) emphasized the importance of leisure activities and social interaction as protective factors against academic burnout.

While these studies provide valuable insights, research on communication arts students in international settings remains limited. The current study addresses this gap by examining how ECA students at Payap University experience and manage academic challenges in a multicultural environment.

(3) Theoretical Framework

This research applies **Academic Stress Theory**, which explains that stress occurs when academic demands exceed students' coping capacity (Misra & McKean, 2000). The theory identifies a cycle involving three main stages: exposure to stressors, emotional and physical responses, and coping strategies.

In this study, stressors include heavy coursework, unclear instructions from lecturers, and challenges in group collaboration. The students' responses often involve feelings of anxiety, frustration, or exhaustion. To manage these demands, students adopt coping mechanisms such as time management, peer support, and using online resources. The desired outcome, according to the theory, is the development of adaptive strategies that improve performance and well-being.

(4) Methodology

A **mixed-methods** design was used to combine quantitative and qualitative insights.

Participants: Fifteen ECA students from Myanmar, India, Korea, China, and Thailand participated in the survey, and four students joined follow-up interviews (two male and two female).

Instruments:

- The **survey** gathered quantitative data on perceptions of workload, understanding of course instructions, and group project experiences.
- The **interviews** explored personal experiences, stress management, and coping strategies in more depth.

Procedure: The survey was distributed online via Google Forms, while interviews were conducted face-to-face and online, depending on the participants' convenience. Interviews were carried out in English, Burmese, or Mon to ensure accurate expression of experiences. All participants were informed of confidentiality and voluntary participation.

Analysis: Quantitative data were analyzed through descriptive statistics (frequency and percentage), while qualitative data were thematically analyzed to identify recurring patterns and direct quotations that reflected students' experiences.

(5) Findings

The findings revealed that English Communication Arts students at Payap University face several interconnected challenges in their academic life. The three most common difficulties identified were heavy workload and time pressure, misunderstanding of course instructions, and problems with group project coordination. Each of these areas contributed to students' overall academic stress and influenced how they coped throughout the semester.

5.1 Heavy Workload and Time Pressure:

As Figure 1 shows, students consistently emphasized that managing heavy workloads and multiple assignments with overlapping deadlines created intense pressure. Although 40% of survey participants categorized this as a minor problem, all interview participants (100%) described it as a significant source of stress. Many expressed that overlapping deadlines often left them feeling fatigued and anxious. Two participants selected ‘major problem’ for understanding course instructions, suggesting that unclear or complex explanations significantly affected their ability to keep up with coursework. As Participant 1 stated, “I often feel overwhelmed with the number of assignments and presentations.” This sense of being overworked was common among students, especially during midterm and final periods. Most students reported using planners, phone reminders, or digital scheduling tools to manage their time more efficiently. However, even with planning, many found it difficult to keep up with constant academic expectations, showing that time management helped but did not completely remove stress.

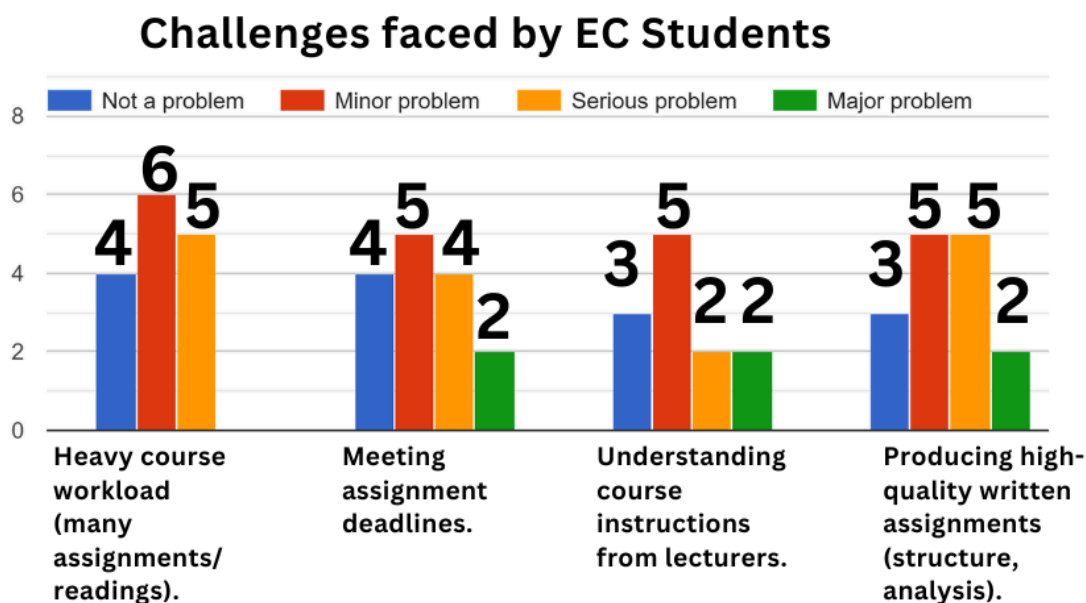


Figure (1) Challenges face by ECA Students

5.2 Understanding Lecturers' Instructions:

Another key issue concerned students' ability to understand course instructions and expectations. About 33.3% of survey participants identified this as a challenge, and three out of four interviewees (75%) mentioned needing to ask for clarification during or after class. One student said, "Sometimes I don't understand exactly what teachers want." Miscommunication often occurred when lecturers used academic or technical terms without clear explanation. This challenge was particularly common for students whose first language was not English. Unclear instructions not only caused confusion but also led to wasted effort when assignments were misinterpreted, which increased stress levels and lowered students' confidence in their academic performance.

5.3 Group Project Coordination:

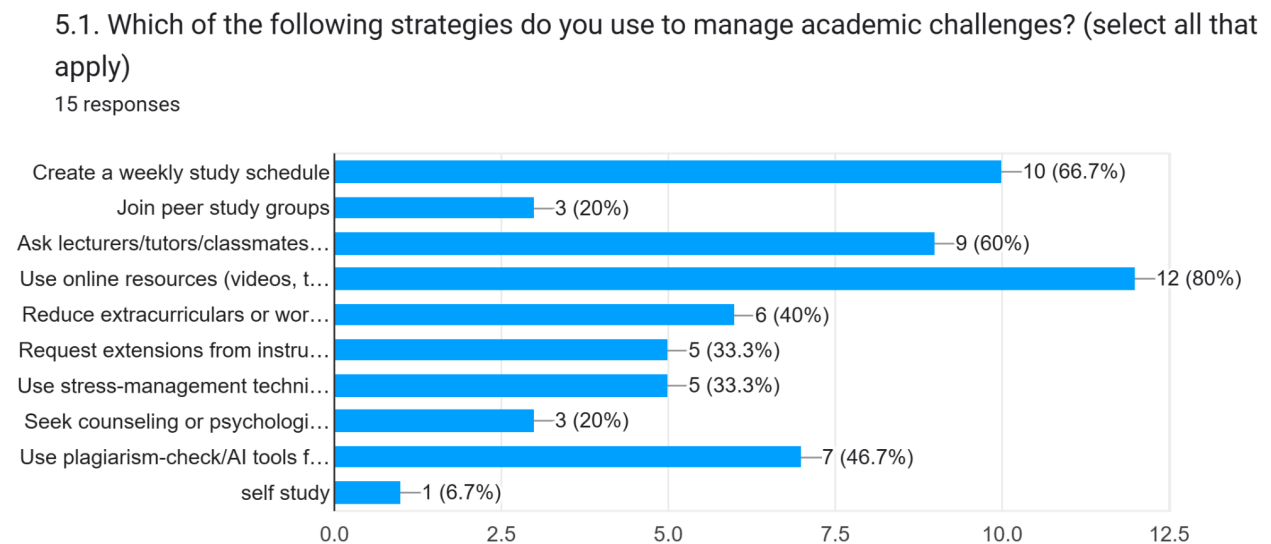
Teamwork was another recurring challenge, with 46.7% of students reporting issues related to group coordination and unequal contributions. Many participants explained that some group members failed to attend meetings or did not contribute fairly to shared projects. As Participant 4 expressed, "Group work is difficult because some students don't cooperate." This problem was amplified by cultural and communication differences among international students, leading to frustration and, in some cases, conflict. Despite these difficulties, several students acknowledged that group projects taught them to become more patient and responsible. Some developed leadership and communication skills as they tried to manage team conflicts and ensure completion of tasks.

5.4 Coping Strategies:

As Figure 2 shows, to manage these academic pressures, students adopted a range of coping strategies. The most common methods were using online tools such as ChatGPT, and creating weekly study schedule (**time planning**), as all four interviewees (100%) reported using tools such as notebooks, mobile calendars, or online task trackers. Another frequently mentioned coping strategy was seeking **peer and online support**. Many students relied on friends, classmates, or online resources such as Google, ChatGPT as well as YouTube tutorials to clarify difficult topics. Additionally, all four interviewees (100%) expressed a strong desire for clearer

and more detailed **feedback from lecturers**, which they believed would help them improve. As one participant explained, “Good feedback helps me know how to improve.” Overall, while students demonstrated a high level of independence and resourcefulness, the need for clearer communication and constructive guidance remained an important area for improvement.

Figure (2) Strategies ECA students use to manage academic challenges



(6) Discussion and Conclusion

6.1 Discussion

The results of this study confirm that the heaviest sources of academic stress among ECA students are heavy workloads, unclear instructions, and group project challenges. These findings align with previous studies by Misra and McKean (2000) and Ahmady et al. (2021), which both identified workload as a dominant cause of academic stress. However, this research provides a more specific understanding of how international communication arts students experience and cope with such issues.

Students’ proactive use of time-management tools and peer collaboration demonstrates resilience and adaptability. These strategies align with Academic Stress Theory, which emphasizes the importance of coping behaviors to balance academic demands. Nevertheless, the study also

shows that these self-initiated efforts are not always sufficient without institutional support. Unclear communication and inconsistent feedback from lecturers were shown to increase confusion, reduce motivation, and sometimes lead to lower academic performance.

Group project challenges further reflect the importance of communication skills and teamwork in international education. Students' complaints about unequal contribution suggest that clearer role assignments and assessment criteria could reduce conflict and improve group outcomes.

All in all, this research highlights that while students are capable of managing academic demands through self-regulation and social support, structural improvements, particularly in instructional clarity, workload distribution, and feedback mechanisms, are needed to create a less stressful and more productive learning environment.

6.1.1 Limitations and Future Research

This study provides valuable insights into the academic challenges faced by ECA students at Payap University, but several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the sample size was small, with 15 survey responses and only four interview participants, which limits the generalizability of the findings. Second, the study relied on self-reported data, which may be influenced by participants' memory, emotions, or willingness to share openly. Additionally, because interviews were conducted in multiple languages (English, Burmese, and Mon), meaning may have shifted slightly during translation. The study also examined challenges within a single program and semester, so long-term patterns remain unexplored. Future research should include a larger and more diverse sample, compare different departments or universities, and use longitudinal designs to track changes in academic stress over time. Further studies could also investigate the effects of specific support interventions, such as writing workshops or teamwork training, on reducing academic stress among international students.

6.2 Conclusion

This study concludes that English Communication Arts students at Payap University face notable academic challenges that stem from heavy course workloads, unclear course instructions, and group project coordination issues. Although many students demonstrate effective coping strategies such as time management and peer collaboration, the persistence of stress suggests that

institutional support should be strengthened. Instructors can help reduce academic stress by providing clearer instructions, maintaining reasonable workload schedules, and giving timely and constructive feedback. The university should also consider implementing workshops on teamwork and stress management to help students develop both academic and emotional resilience. Overall, ECA students are capable and resourceful but often struggle to balance multiple academic expectations. Supporting their efforts through better communication, structured guidance, and feedback will not only improve their academic success but also enhance their overall learning experience at Payap University.

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